



AGAINST HIMSELF

If there was one certainty heading into the 2025 World Athletics Championships in Tokyo, it was that Armand Duplantis would win the pole vault.

The standard he has set is such that anything short of a world record now feels like an anti-climax. On September 15, under the lights at the Tokyo National Stadium, the Swede once again lived up to that expectation.

Duplantis cruised through the early rounds before sealing his third world title with a clearance of 6.15m. He then raised the bar beyond his own world record of 6.29m, turning the contest into a familiar duel with himself.

After two narrow failures, the drama peaked on his final attempt. Duplantis soared over 6.30m to shatter the world record yet again, the 14th time he has improved the mark and the fourth occasion in 2025 alone.

Greece's Emmanouil Karalis claimed silver, his best jump finishing 30cm short of Duplantis' winning height.

Along with the gold medal, Duplantis also pocketed another \$100,000 world-record bonus, prompting World Athletics president Sebastian Coe to joke, "One more world record and we lose our Christmas party. Two more and we lose the summer party."

FINALLY, THEIRS

After an agonising 18-year wait marked by repeated near misses, Royal Challengers Bengaluru finally claimed its maiden Indian Premier League title in 2025.

RCB edged past Punjab Kings in the final in Ahmedabad on June 3 to end a drought that had long defined the franchise. The triumph was the product of sustained recalibration, as the team moved away from the top-heavy, star-driven model of the 2010s towards a more balanced and cohesive unit.

Virat Kohli, ever the constant, anchored the batting through the season, finishing with 657 runs, including eight half-centuries, at a strike rate of 144.71. The bowling attack was led by the relentless Josh Hazlewood, whose 22 wickets provided control and penetration. Holding it together was first-time captain Rajat Patidar, under whom RCB finished second in the league stage, behind Punjab Kings.

RCB made a statement in Qualifier 1, skittling PBKS for 101 before chasing the target inside 10 overs. Opener Phil Salt, among the most astute of RCB's signings, struck a blistering fifty.

In the final, Kohli again played the stabilising role with a 35-ball 40, while brisk contributions from around him lifted RCB to a competitive 190 for nine. The bowlers then maintained constant pressure, never allowing Punjab to break free, and sealed a six-run win that finally delivered the title RCB had chased for nearly two decades.

